EGGLESS GOURMET COFFEE & WALNUT TEA CAKE

Tender coffee-infused crumb • toasted walnuts • delicate espresso glaze

Yield	1 loaf, 20 × 10 cm tin	**Oven**	170°C conventional / 160°C fan
Bake time	45–55 minutes	**Skill level**	Confident beginner

Recipe note: This cake is completely eggless. Toast the walnuts for a deeper flavour, and let the loaf cool completely before glazing.

Ingredients

For the cake

Ingredient	Quantity
Plain flour	180 g
Caster sugar	145 g
Baking powder	5 g
Baking soda	1.5 g
Fine salt	2 g
Walnuts, finely ground after toasting	25 g
Unsalted butter, softened	70 g
Neutral oil	35 g
Plain full-fat yoghurt, room temperature	100 g
Whole milk	75 g
Instant espresso powder	5 g
Vanilla extract	3 g
Lemon juice	5 g
Walnuts, toasted and roughly chopped	65 g

For the espresso glaze

- 90 g icing sugar, sifted
- 15 g unsalted butter, melted
- 12–18 g strong espresso, cooled slightly
- A tiny pinch of fine salt

Optional finish

6–8 walnut halves; 5 g finely grated dark chocolate (optional).

Method

1. Prepare the tin and oven

Heat the oven to 170°C conventional or 160°C fan. Grease a 20 × 10 cm loaf tin and line the base and long sides with baking parchment, leaving a little overhang.

2. Toast the walnuts

Spread the walnuts on a tray and toast at 160°C for 7–10 minutes, checking often. They should smell nutty and look lightly golden, not dark. Cool completely. Grind 25 g finely; roughly chop the remaining 65 g. Keep separate.

3. Make the coffee infusion

Warm the 75 g milk until just warm, not boiling. Whisk in 5 g instant espresso powder until dissolved, then stir in the vanilla extract. Set aside to cool until lukewarm.

4. Mix the dry ingredients

Whisk together the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt and ground walnuts so the raising agents are evenly distributed.

5. Cream butter and sugar

Beat the softened butter and caster sugar for 2–3 minutes, until creamy and slightly lighter. Scrape the bowl to avoid unmixed butter at the bottom.

6. Add oil and yoghurt

Gradually whisk in the neutral oil. Add the yoghurt in 2–3 additions, mixing until the base looks mostly smooth. Do not add extra flour if it looks slightly curdled.

7. Combine wet and dry mixtures

Add the dry mixture in three additions, alternating with the coffee milk in two additions. Begin and end with the dry mixture. Add the lemon juice and mix briefly. Stop as soon as no dry flour remains; overmixing can make the loaf dense.

8. Fold in walnuts

Use a flexible spatula to fold in the 65 g chopped toasted walnuts with broad strokes from the bottom of the bowl upwards. The batter should be thick, spoonable and naturally coffee-coloured.

9. Fill and bake

Transfer batter to the lined tin and level the top. Tap the tin gently once on the worktop. Bake for 45–55 minutes; begin checking at 40 minutes. If the top browns too quickly, loosely cover with foil near the end.

10. Check doneness

Insert a skewer into the centre. It should come out clean or with a few moist crumbs, but no wet batter. The top should spring back gently. If using a probe thermometer, the centre is usually around 96–98°C. If underbaked, return to the oven for 5 minutes and check again.

11. Cool completely

Leave the loaf in the tin for 12–15 minutes, then lift it out using the parchment and transfer to a wire rack. Let it cool completely before glazing; a warm loaf can melt the glaze and make it run off.

12. Make the espresso glaze

Sift the icing sugar into a bowl. Stir in melted butter and salt, then add espresso gradually, starting with 12 g. Mix until smooth and thick but pourable. Add the remaining espresso a little at a time only if needed.

13. Glaze and finish

Pour the glaze over the fully cooled loaf and guide it gently towards the edges. Allow it to set for 15–25 minutes. Add walnut halves and optional grated dark chocolate. For neat slices, use a sharp serrated knife and wipe it clean between cuts.

Professional pastry notes

- **Weigh precisely:** a digital scale is particularly important for the small quantities of baking soda and baking powder.
- **Use room-temperature ingredients:** softened butter and yoghurt combine more evenly.
- **Do not overmix:** once flour is added, mix only until combined for a tender crumb.
- **Keep the walnuts distinct:** grind the 25 g portion finely, not into a paste; chop the remaining walnuts so they remain visible in the slice.

- **Adjust glaze carefully:** it should fall from a spoon in a thick ribbon. Thin with espresso a few drops at a time, or thicken with a little sifted icing sugar.

Storage and serving

Store in an airtight container for 2–3 days in a cool room. In hot weather, refrigerate and bring slices towards room temperature before serving. For longer storage, freeze the unglazed, completely cooled loaf, well wrapped, for up to 2 months; thaw fully before glazing.

Allergen note: contains wheat/gluten, dairy and walnuts. Check ingredient labels for cross-contact if serving anyone with an allergy.